Scaffolding

Preparing support and deciding when to remove it

Use a scaffold when a specific barrier prevents students from attempting the intended learning successfully. Keep the goal clear and plan how students will work without the support.

How to do it well

1 Diagnose the barrier. Identify whether pupils lack knowledge, cannot coordinate the steps, are overloaded by presentation, or need a cue to select a known process.

2 Break the process into meaningful steps. Sequence the task so pupils can focus on one decision at a time while still seeing how the parts contribute to the whole.

3 Select a targeted support. Use a model, worked example, prompt, frame, word bank, visual cue, checklist or partially completed response that addresses the diagnosed barrier.

4 Keep the thinking with the pupil. The scaffold should cue attention or structure action; it should not complete the crucial reasoning on the pupil's behalf.

5 Check and adjust. Use responses during practice to decide whether to re-model, retain, reduce or remove the support.

6 Plan the fade before use. Decide which element will disappear first and what evidence will indicate readiness for the next level of independence.

What this sounds like

“Use this opening frame to state your claim. You will choose the evidence and explain the link yourself; the frame does not supply those decisions.”

Classroom example. In English, pupils need to explain how evidence supports a claim. A frame supplies the paragraph structure while pupils choose and interpret the quotation. Once they can build the link, the opening phrases are removed. The scaffold supports expression without replacing the interpretation that the task is intended to develop.

Top tips that make the technique work

Name the barrier. Decide whether the student needs help with knowledge, language, organisation or a particular process step.

Scaffold the obstacle. A vocabulary bank helps with expression; it will not repair an untaught concept.

Make support optional where appropriate. Students who can already work independently should not have to complete unnecessary scaffolding.

Preserve the decision. Give a starting cue or structure without supplying the thinking the task is meant to develop.

Plan the withdrawal. Decide what successful performance would justify removing a cue, worked step or sentence frame.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Match temporary support to the diagnosed need.	Assigning a permanent scaffold by pupil label.
Keep the curricular goal ambitious.	Removing every support at once because time has passed.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Provide Scaffolds for Difficult Tasks | DistillED - Fading Support